

58 Permission, requests, and offers

"Can," "could," and "may" are used to ask permission to do something, or to ask someone to do something for you. They can also be used to offer to help someone.

See also:

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58.1 ASKING PERMISSION AND MAKING REQUESTS

"Can" is the most common modal verb used to ask permission or to make a request.

Can I have some popcorn?



Yes, you can.

Informal answers use "can" as well.

"Could" replaces "can" for more formal situations, such as in business or to talk to strangers.

Excuse me, could I sit here, please?



I'm sorry, but that seat is taken.

Negative answers can be more polite by adding "I'm sorry" or "I'm afraid."

"Please" is used in polite requests.

"May" can also be used in formal situations.

May I make an appointment?



Of course.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

Can I borrow your pen?



Excuse me, could you open the door for me?



Can I have this in a smaller size?



May I reserve a table for 7pm?

